“The last time I saw you we were at . . .,” I’ll say, “Oh, yes . . .”

You just have to do something like that to avoid hurting people. On an average day when I was president, I saw about eighty people, ranging from presidents and prime ministers to the newest multiple sclerosis poster child. Some days, there were more than twenty appointments on my schedule, from about nine in the morning until at least five in the afternoon. As the day passes, you have to shift within a few seconds from conducting a meeting about a serious international crisis to greeting the newest Miss America or meeting in the Rose Garden with a group of champion athletes or being photographed during a heart-tugging visit from a disabled child. You get introduced to hundreds of people, hear their names only once, and don’t always put together a name with a face in a moment’s time.

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For years, I’ve heard the question: “How could an actor be president?” I’ve sometimes wondered how you could be president and not be an actor.

When you’ve been in the profession I was in, you get accustomed to criticism in the press—true and untrue, fair and unfair—and learn to take what you read about yourself and others with a big dose of salt. Gossip columnists and critics become a part of your life. A picture you’ve made may be panned by a critic and you’ll say to yourself, “You know, that’s a pretty good movie and the audience likes it.” It teaches you that the press isn’t always right, and prepares you for criticism in politics; you develop a skepticism about what you read, and take it in stride. That kind of experience helps when you start reading things about yourself as president.

Regarding the press, I’ve always believed a free press is as vital to America as the Constitution and the Bill of Rights. A